

Chapter 9 — MTurk and other crowd platforms

Use cases need operational platforms

Learning objectives

- By the end of this part

Amazon Mechanical Turk overview

- Amazon Mechanical Turk
- Through a web interface
- The platform is one of the best-known venues for crowd labor in research and industry

HIT workflow: post, complete, review, pay

- Requesters create Human Intelligence Tasks
- Workers browse available tasks and choose which to complete
- After submission, the requester reviews results and pays when the work is satisfactory
- Feedback builds worker reputation and influences access to harder tasks

Example 9.11 — MTurk Product-Description Labeling

- Example 9.11 — hands-on module
- Example 9.11 walks a product-description labeling campaign
- Workers read descriptions and tag categories such as electronics, clothing, or home goods
- Those labels then train recommendation models
- Explore the chapter example module
- View files: ``modules/chapter9/example11/``

Prolific for research recruitment

- Prolific targets academic research
- Participants are pre-screened to meet study criteria
- Compared with general microtask markets

CrowdFlower and Clickworker

- CrowdFlower, now Figure Eight, supports annotation, machine learning tasks
- Clickworker, based in Germany, focuses on writing, translation, categorization
- Platform choice should match task type, geography, and quality needs

Choosing a platform

- MTurk remains a common default for flexible microtasks and labeling
- Prolific is often stronger when ethics screening and survey quality matter most
- CrowdFlower and Clickworker emphasize managed annotation workflows or European language
- Teams should align platform features with recruitment criteria, pay norms

Takeaways

- MTurk operationalizes crowdsourcing through Human Intelligence Tasks, review, payment
- Product-description labeling shows how category tags feed downstream models
- Prolific, CrowdFlower

Next

- Complete the quiz for this part
- Ethical obligations around fair pay, privacy, and harmful work conditions